



Photosynth

What is Photosynth?

It's a not-so-perfect-just-yet technology from Microsoft Live Labs that takes a collection of photos and analyses them for similarities. It then displays a 3D scene reconstructed from the photos. You'll have to look at it in action to see what this means!

Why is it special?

Microsoft plans to make this technology Web-based, which means that in the future it might be possible to browse different sections of Web sites or view your photos just the way you would move around in a virtual reality space.

How does it work?

In a Photosynth session, digital photos are scanned by pattern recognition algorithms. When photos of the same object are found, the software compares portions of these images to create reference points on a canvas. Using these points, the image is converted into a 3D model.

Who is developing it?

Photosynth is a collaboration between the University of Washington and Microsoft Research using Seadragon technologies, a start-up that Microsoft acquired.

When did it come onto the scene?

Photosynth has been in development since July 2006, and continues to be improved upon.

Where can I preview this thing?

Photosynth only runs on Windows XP SP2 and above. You can preview it at <http://labs.live.com/photosynth/InstallForVista.htm?collection=none&showErrors=0&st=sanmarco/index1.sxs>. To preview it, you'll have to let it get installed on your computer.

problems in the stabilisation of new features in Linux-based operating systems. New features take too long to come out, and this was discussed. Raven Zachary, open source analyst for the 451 Group, believes that in regards to the usability of Linux, no innovations were happening.

The Linux Foundation has support from 70 corporate and non-profit players including Intel, Oracle, IBM, Cisco, Motorola, Nokia, NTT, Dell, Red Hat,



and Sun. These companies use Linux-based servers, and so want the innovations, as well as more stabilisation in Linux OSes and open source software.

Dell's announcement to ship desktops and notebooks with Ubuntu pre-loaded could well have zapped Microsoft. Microsoft continues to strike deals with Linux-based OSes—Novell, Xandros, and recently, with Linspire. These deals contain clauses for creating interoperability between Microsoft products and Linux.

But will Microsoft versus the FOSS community ever end? We see two possibilities.

After signing their agreement with Novell, which we've talked about, Microsoft wanted Red Hat and Ubuntu to sign a cross-licensing deal with them, but neither party was interested. If a miffed Microsoft decides to file a suit against the top Linux distributors, the latter will, naturally, have to bear the legal expenses to defend

themselves. This could even affect the business models of Linux distributors. Even if a court declares the patent infringement matter invalid, Microsoft might decide on another set of patents to use to sue, dragging the matter to court right until FOSS developers give up. The constant fear of litigations will disturb open source projects.

The second possibility we're talking about is *Linux* suing Microsoft for violation of patents. How? Well, Linux springs from UNIX. "Think how long UNIX has been around," says Andrew Updegrove, software license attorney and board member of the Linux Foundation. About this, Linus Torvalds says, "It's certainly a lot more likely that Microsoft violates patents than Linux does."

Basic operating system theory was pretty much done by the end of the 1960s." So if the threats continue, the Linux and FOSS communities could retaliate. Of course, we don't know what's going on Ballmer's head—he could well have some other tricks up his sleeve!

THE PRESENT AND THE FUTURE

Indian Bloggers Meet Up

Censorship and Citizen Journalism have been recently discussed and debated in the media as well as on the Web. To discuss issues pertaining to the blogosphere, an "un-conference" for the Indian blogging community was held at the Symbiosis Centre of Information Technology (SCIT) campus, Pune. About 200 enthusiasts as well as veteran bloggers, along with sponsors from large portals, IT companies, Web start-ups, and Web marketing firms were present. The primary

organiser was Tarun Chandel, who was a student at SCIT.

At the event, Rediff unveiled their new service—Blogshowcase—where bloggers can showcase their blog content and get recognition through votes and comments. The service is still in beta: registration is currently invitation-based, but will become open for the public soon. Rediff spokesperson Jasmeet Singh, vice president for product marketing, said, "This is a platform for users to showcase their own content from anywhere on the Web through RSS feeds. These feeds get updated frequently, and the blogs are offered in an organised format to those who visit our site."

Also present were the marketing folks from Purple Nova, a marketing firm, with a new product that turns a PC into a Web server. A spokesman for Sulekha.com, Sudhir Syal, spoke about the concept of bringing blogs to the print medium. Some Web start-ups pitched new blog concepts: SMS Gupshup, an "SMS blogging" site, talked about blogging through SMS, and Fropper's ezBlogs offering simplifies blogging with predefined templates and such.

The participants discussed blogging-related topics—like how to start a blog, blogging as business, photo blogging, blogging from the Indian perspective, podcasting, and so on. A woman blogger, "Melody," talked about the pitfalls of freely-available information and its misuse. A podcasting talk by the publishers of *Poorna Puna*, a youth magazine, was enthralling. Indian podcasters from IndiCast, an Indian podcasting site (yes, there are some!) were also present.

However, several bloggers present at the event felt the start-ups and services offered by the portals for bloggers were "not cool enough." But in general, it was a healthy discussion about how to better the Indian blogosphere. ☒